- **Windows-only software:** No Boot Camp on Apple Silicon. Your options:
  - **Cloud:** Use the vendor's web/SaaS version if it exists.
  - **Virtualization:** Parallels/VMs can run Windows on ARM (not x86 Windows). Many x86 Windows apps run inside via emulation – but drivers and some security/anti-cheat remain blockers.
  - **Remote desktop:** Keep a Windows box (home or cloud) and RDP into it for the few tasks you can't replace.

Choose Air vs Pro:

- Mostly Office/web, light edits, and mobility? Air.
- Frequent long renders, compiles, color-critical work, or want more ports and sustained performance? Pro.

Do note that macOS is well supported for mainstream productivity and creative work; if your institute/business mandates a Windows-only desktop client (tax, ERP, compliance), confirm a browser or remote workaround before you switch.

ChromeOS Flex: revive, simplify, and save

What it is: Free ChromeOS variant for many Intel/AMD PCs/Macs. Ideal to repurpose older laptops for school, home, NGOs, kiosks.

What to expect: Fast boots, low maintenance, strong security, web/PWA-first workflow, optional Linux container for coding. No Android apps on Flex. Check Google's certified model list; many unlisted devices still work for core tasks.

Choose it when the browser is your OS and you want near-zero upkeep.

Linux: when it fits, and dual-boot hygiene

Who benefits: Developers (containers, toolchains), privacy-minded users, and owners of older hardware. Modern desktops are friendly; package managers simplify life.

Mind the gaps: Some enterprise VPNs, niche drivers, and proprietary creative apps may be missing or fiddly. Gaming via Proton is good – but not universal.

Dual-boot best practices (Windows + Linux):

1. Back up first.
2. Install Windows first, then Linux (GRUB adds Windows cleanly).
3. Disable Windows Fast Startup to avoid NTFS issues.
4. Keep Secure Boot on if supported; otherwise, temporarily disable.
5. Use a shared NTFS data partition (or cloud) for cross-OS files.
6. Avoid hibernating one OS and booting the other; use NTP for clock sync.
7. Keep a Linux live USB and a Windows recovery drive handy.

(Apple Silicon dual-boot with Windows is not supported; use VMs or remote Windows instead. Many Linux distros run on Apple Silicon with community effort – assess drivers.

DECISION SHORTCUTS

- Office + web + calls, max battery: Windows on ARM or MacBook Air.
- Legacy Windows apps, AAA gaming, broad driver support: Windows on x86.
- Sustained creative/pro workloads, color, ports: MacBook Pro.
- Revive old laptop for school/home browsing: ChromeOS Flex.
- Dev/privacy/control or older hardware optimization: Linux (dual-boot with Windows if needed).

Step-by-step: app-compatibility checklist before you buy

1) Make a non-negotiables list.

Office suite, conferencing, creative tools, IDEs/SDKs/Docker, VPN/security, finance/tax utilities, printers/scanners/tablets, and games.

2) Map each item to the platform.

- **macOS (Air/Pro):** Prefer native Apple Silicon builds; verify Rosetta works acceptably where needed; for Windows-only apps, confirm SaaS, virtualization (Windows on ARM VM), or remote desktop is viable. Check plug-in ecosystems for DAWs/creative suites.
- **Linux:** Look for native packages/Flatsnap/AppImage; check Wine/Proton databases for specific Windows apps/games; confirm VPN and device drivers.
- **ChromeOS Flex:** Confirm web/PWA alternatives; only use Linux container if comfortable; accept no Android apps.

3) Verify peripherals.

Search "[device] driver macOS Apple Silicon," "[device] Windows ARM driver," or "[device] Linux support." Confirm scanners, label printers, drawing tablets, card/token middleware.

4) Test in advance if possible.

- **Live USB:** Trial Linux/Flex without installing.
- **Trial builds:** Install macOS/Windows app trials; test Rosetta on a borrowed Apple Silicon Mac or Prism on a Windows ARM device.
- **Remote/VM pilot:** Spin up a short-term cloud/VM to validate a Windows-only workflow from macOS.

5) Decide on fallbacks.

If a blocker remains, is a web version OK? Will you keep a small Windows PC at home, or run a Windows ARM VM, or choose x86 Windows instead? d